



How Do We Know?

WisdomForge Booklet — Ages 5–10

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About This Book

This booklet is the six thinking sittings called *How to Think*. Those sittings are live for little, young, emerging, and adult. The booklet is the text. The parent is the teacher. The guide is optional. A talking tool may help with a word. It may not think for you.

It is not the Critical Thinking Hour books (*Little Thinkers*, *Young Minds*, *Emerging Adults*, *Adults*). Those are a different product: longer, illustrated hours on the Academy shelf. This pack is the kitchen-table loop — six sittings a house can actually walk. It is not a hosted kids chatbot. Do not invent sittings. Do not skip to the capstone.

How to Think is a path with names. Sitting 1 writes the claim and asks how we know. Sitting 2 says the other idea until a nod. Sitting 3 names what would change a small map. Sitting 4 freezes a foggy word. Sitting 5 catches a sentence that is only smooth. Sitting 6 walks the whole loop on paper. If you skip a name because it feels slow, you will still clap, fight, or paste the sentence into a machine. The names are there so you can notice the skip.

The parent stays in the loop. Human first. Guide second. Evaluate always. If a week is too tender, refusal is a complete week. Nothing in this booklet asks a child to dump a wound, target a classmate, or comfort an adult. Keep apples, weather, game rules, and “always.” The adult sittings in this unit exist so a grown-up can be seen using the same marks without a scoreboard.

“Doubt is an uneasy and dissatisfied state from which we struggle to free ourselves and pass into the state of belief.” — Charles S. Peirce, “The Fixation of Belief” (1877)

Chapter 1: How Do We Know?



Illustration for Chapter 1

A claim is a sentence that might be true. Thinking starts when we ask how we know — before we clap, fight, or ask a machine.

Objective. The child can take one sentence from the day, write it as a claim, and mark LOOK / ASK / TRY / NOT YET before believing it.

For the grown-up in the room. This is sitting 1, *Claim and Check*. You are teaching a pause, not cynicism. Use apples, weather, a game rule. The model may not be the judge. If they cannot point to a check, the sentence is still a rumor. If you model “because I said so” as the only how, they will take every other claim to a fluent tool that never looks either. One marked paper this week is the curriculum.

The claim on the table. Someone says, “It always rains on picnic days.” That is a claim. It sounds finished. It is not yet known. Write it down. Now you can look at it. A claim you never write will hide inside a feeling.

Four marks. LOOK: what can eyes or a calendar show? ASK: who was there? TRY: can we test a small version? NOT YET: we do not know, and that is an honest answer. Pick one mark. Do that mark. Then decide.

LOOK is the eyes-in-the-room check. Count the crackers. Open the curtain. Read the clock. If the claim cannot be looked at here, do not fake a look. ASK is for when another person holds the fact: who saw the rain, who made the rule, who counted. TRY is a small test you can finish today — not a science fair. NOT YET is the mark grown-ups skip because it feels unfinished. Unfinished is allowed. A forced LOOK that did not happen is a lie with a confident voice.

You only need one mark per claim. Children who try to do all four will stall and call thinking boring. One mark, then a decision or a wait. The paper holds the wait so nobody has to perform certainty at dinner.

The model’s shortcut. A talking tool will answer as if it already looked. Fluency is a style. Looking is a check. If the tool speaks first, the child learns that finished sentences are the same as true ones. Close the tool until the paper exists.

Eyes before mouths. If the claim is about the sky, look at the sky. If it is about a jar, count the apples. If it is about a person who is not here, you may have to say NOT YET. NOT YET is not failure. It is the honest mark when the check is not in the room. Grown-ups skip this because they are busy. Busy is not a check.

Why write it. A claim in the air changes shape. On paper it stays still long enough to mark. The child who writes “the cat always hides” can look under the chair. The child who only feels sure cannot look at a feeling. Paper is a kindness to the truth.

Sitting big idea. A claim is not a fact until someone can say how they know.

If they say “I just know.”: Knowing still has a how. If you cannot name it, say NOT YET.

If they say “The tool already said.”: The tool said. That is not a look.

Integrity. We do not repeat a sentence we have not checked as if we knew.

Dinner. What claim did we almost believe today, and how would we know?

- Keep stakes tiny. Skip adult wounds. - Praise the mark, not a win.

Words to Remember

“Doubt is an uneasy and dissatisfied state from which we struggle to free ourselves and pass into the state of belief.” — Charles S. Peirce, “The Fixation of Belief” (1877)

*“A claim is not a fact until someone can say how they know.” — WisdomForge sitting
*Claim and Check**

Big Idea

Write the sentence. Mark LOOK / ASK / TRY / NOT YET. The tool waits.

Try This

1. Write one claim from today on paper. 2. Circle LOOK, ASK, TRY, or NOT YET. 3. Do that one thing before any guide speaks.

What this is not: a quiz. If they mark NOT YET, they passed. The grown-up who says “just guess” undoes the sitting. Keep the paper on the fridge for a day so the mark stays still.

Ask a Grown-Up

What claim did you believe this week, and how did you know?

Chapter 2: Until They Could Nod



Illustration for Chapter 2

Kind hearing is not agreeing. It is saying the other person's idea so clearly they could nod.

Objective. The child can retell someone else's idea until that person (or a grown-up standing in) would nod — before answering.

For the grown-up in the room. This is sitting 2, *Steel-Man*. Nod test, not a debate club. Do not make them steel-man a wound. You model it on a small disagreement first. If you only demand the nod when you are winning, they will learn that hearing is a trick. Use a chore, a game, a story character. The first nod of the week should be you nodding at them.

The cartoon version. When we are mad, we shrink the other idea until it is silly. Then we win at a cartoon. The cartoon cannot nod. Real thinking waits for a sentence the other person would sign.

The nod test. “You mean _____. Did I get it?” If they say no, try again. The guide may hunt unfairness. It may not write the hearing for you.

A nod is a small thing. It is not a treaty. It is one sentence the other person would sign. If you need three tries, that is the sitting working. If you need ten, the disagreement may be too hot for this week — stop. If you never ask, you are guessing. Guessing dressed as listening is how cartoons get written.

Why it is hard. Hearing well feels like losing. It is not. It is making the table honest. If you cannot say their idea, you are still fighting fog.

The grown-up goes first. Children will not steel-man a sibling if they have never seen an adult do it without scoring points. Say their small complaint back until they nod. Then you may explain the rule. If you skip the nod, they learn that “listening” means waiting to talk.

What the tool may not do. A model can write a kind paragraph in someone else’s voice. That is a costume of hearing. The nod has to come from a person in the room. If there is no person, practice on a story character with a grown-up as the nodder. Do not paste a classmate.

Sitting big idea. You have not answered until they could nod.

If they say “That’s just agreeing.”: Nodding that you heard is not nodding that they are right.

If they say “I already know what they think.”: Then the nod is cheap. If it is expensive, you did not know yet.

Integrity. We do not paste a person’s words into a tool to “hear” them.

Dinner. Whose idea did we say back until they could nod?

- Keep it to a game rule or a chore, not a family wound. - You go first.

Words to Remember

*“He who knows only his own side of the case, knows little of that.” — John Stuart Mill,
On Liberty, chapter 2 (1859)*

*“You have not answered until they could nod.” — WisdomForge sitting *Steel-Man**

Big Idea

Say their idea until a nod. Then you may speak.

Try This

1. Pick a small disagreement. 2. Say their side in one sentence. 3. Ask: “Would you nod?” Fix it before you answer.

What this is not: making them like the rule. The nod is “you heard me,” not “I give up.” If the other person will not nod because they want a fight, you still did the work. Stop. Do not escalate.

Ask a Grown-Up

When did someone hear you well enough that you could nod?

Chapter 3: What Would Change Your Mind?



Illustration for Chapter 3

A belief you would never drop is a jersey, not a map.

Objective. The child can name one thing that would make them change a small belief — or honestly say they are not ready to name it.

For the grown-up in the room. This is sitting 3. Keep it tiny: “our team always wins,” “it never snows in May.” You change a small map in front of them first. Do not force a conversion. If you never change a grocery plan when the store is out, they will not believe the sitting. Show one then / saw / now of your own, about something that does not wound them.

Maps and jerseys. A map can be redrawn when the road is different. A jersey stays on so the team can see you. Both have a place. Thinking uses maps. Cheering uses jerseys. Trouble starts when we wear a jersey and call it a map.

A map answers: how would we know we were wrong? A jersey answers: whose side are we on? Picnic weather can be a map. A favorite color can stay a jersey. The sitting is not trying to take jerseys away. It is trying to stop a house from calling a jersey a map and then being cruel when the road changes.

The brave sentence. “If I saw ____, I would change.” Write it. If you cannot write it, the belief is a jersey today. That can be honest. Do not pretend.

The model’s humble last line. Tools are good at writing “I might be wrong.” Meaning it on Tuesday is the work. Paper first.

Tiny maps only. “Our picnic always gets rained on” can change after one sunny Saturday. “I am a bad kid” is not a map for this sitting. If the belief is about a person they love, stop. The sitting is about weather, games, and “always.” You can show a change on a grocery list. You do not dump adult failures on them.

Then / saw / now. If they do change: write what they thought, what they saw, what they think now. Three short lines. That is the bravery. Do not demand an apology tour.

Sitting big idea. If nothing could change your mind, you are not mapping. You are wearing a team shirt.

If they say “Changing means I was dumb.”: Changing means you saw more. Staying when the road changed is the stuck thing.

If they say “I don’t want to.”: Then say jersey. Do not call it a map.

Integrity. We do not let a tool write our “I changed” sentence and then sign our name.

Dinner. What would we have to see to change our mind about one small thing?

- If they cry, stop. - You name a change of your own first.

Words to Remember

*“The criterion of the scientific status of a theory is its falsifiability, or refutability, or testability.” — Karl Popper, *Conjectures and Refutations* (1963)*

*“If nothing could change your mind, you are wearing a jersey, not reading a map.” — WisdomForge sitting *What Would Change Your Mind**

Big Idea

Name what would change you — or admit you are cheering.

Try This

1. Write one small belief. 2. Write: IF I SAW ____, I WOULD CHANGE. 3. If you cannot, write JERSEY and stop. No tool first.

What this is not: a conversion. A jersey on a game day is allowed. The honesty is calling it a jersey. The harm is calling a jersey a map and then punishing anyone who brings a new road.

Ask a Grown-Up

When did you change your mind because you saw more?

Chapter 4: What Do Those Words Mean?



Illustration for Chapter 4

Before we fight, we say the word out loud until we mean the same thing.

Objective. The child can stop a disagreement long enough to write what a word means in this room.

For the grown-up in the room. Fair, always, never, cheat, share. Ordinary words hide two jobs. You are teaching a pause, not spelling class. The model may not invent the house meaning. Write the sentence when you are calm. If you only define the word when you are angry, it becomes a weapon and they will not bring you the next fight-word.

Two rooms, one word. “Fair” can mean same number or same chance. “Always” can mean every time or often enough to annoy. If two people use the same word for two jobs, they will fight forever and think the other is cheating.

The house sentence. IN THIS ROOM it means _____. Write it. Then argue if you still need to. A talking tool will pick a dictionary meaning. Dictionaries do not live in your kitchen.

Fair is the usual fog. Same number of crackers is one fair. Same chance at the last cookie is another. Extra time because someone is smaller is a third. None of these is cheating if the house said it. All of them feel like cheating if the house never said it. Write the house fair before anyone yells.

If the house never writes it, the loudest voice becomes the dictionary. A fluent tool is very good at being that voice. The sitting is cheaper: one sentence on a card. Put the card where the fight usually starts.

The tool’s extra meanings. After the house sentence exists, you may ask a guide for two other meanings of the word. Keep the house one. The point is to see that words travel. Traveling is not permission to swap meanings mid-fight.

Sitting big idea. If the word is fog, the argument is fog.

If they say “Everyone knows what it means.”: If everyone knew, the fight would already be over. Say it anyway.

If they say “That’s just being picky.”: The fight is hiding in the word. Name the word.

Integrity. We do not let a tool pick the meaning of a house word.

Dinner. What word did we use today that might have meant two things?

- Skip adult legal words. - Apply the sentence to your own mouth first.

Words to Remember

*“For the meaning of a word is its use in the language.” — Ludwig Wittgenstein,
Philosophical Investigations, §43 (1953)*

*“If the word is fog, the argument is fog.” — WisdomForge sitting *Say What You Mean**

Big Idea

Write what the word means here. Then talk.

Try This

1. Pick a fight-word from today (fair, never, cheat, share). 2. Each person says what they meant. 3. Write: IN THIS ROOM it means _____. Guide closed until the sentence exists.

What this is not: a spelling test or a courtroom. One house sentence is enough. If they write it and still disagree about the cookie, you now know you are disagreeing about the cookie, not about English.

Ask a Grown-Up

What does “fair” mean in this house?

Chapter 5: Smooth Is Not the Same as True



Illustration for Chapter 5

A sentence can sound finished and still be wrong. We catch the smooth one.

Objective. The child can pause a smooth sentence and mark LOOK / ASK / TRY / NOT YET before believing it.

For the grown-up in the room. Ads, show hosts, and talking tools all do smooth. Use a low-stakes claim. You are teaching the catch, not mockery. Catch an ad or your own rant first. If the only smoothness you catch is theirs, they will hide the finished sentences they like. Catch yours at dinner in the same four marks.

Finished-sounding stones. Some sentences come out polished, like a stone from a stream. They feel done. “This tool always knows.” “Nobody does that anymore.” Smooth is a style. True still needs a check.

Costume of proof. Numbers, calm voice, complete sentences — those are clothes evidence sometimes wears. Clothes are not the walk. If you cannot point to a look or a try, you heard a costume.

Ads are practice. An ad can say “everyone has one” in a warm voice. Everyone is a big word. Look: do the people in this house have one? Ask: who counted everyone? Try: would we still want it if the voice were quiet? Often the mark is NOT YET, and that is enough to walk past the shelf.

Warm voice plus “everyone” is a costume pair. You do not need a lecture on advertising. You need one paused sentence and one look around the room. If the answer is “we don’t know who everyone is,” you already caught it.

Catch yours first. If you only catch the child’s smoothness, they will hide. Catch a headline at dinner. Use the same four marks. They are watching whether finished prose gets applause in this house.

Sitting big idea. Smooth is a style. True still needs a check.

If they say “It sounded sure.”: Sure is a tone. We still look.

If they say “It used a number.”: A number can be a costume too. Where did it come from?

Integrity. We do not repeat a smooth claim we have not checked as if we knew.

Dinner. What smooth sentence did we almost believe today?

- Do not mock them for liking a smooth story. - Skip conspiracy.

Words to Remember

*“A reliable way to make people believe in falsehoods is frequent repetition, because familiarity is not easily distinguished from truth.” — Daniel Kahneman, *Thinking, Fast and Slow* (2011)*

*“Smooth is a style. True still needs a check.” — WisdomForge sitting *Catch the Fluent Claim**

Big Idea

Catch the finished-sounding sentence. Then look.

Try This

1. Listen for one smooth sentence (ad, show, tool). 2. Write it down. 3. Mark LOOK / ASK / TRY / NOT YET. Do one look or try before the guide speaks.

What this is not: teaching them that every smooth sentence is a lie. Songs can be smooth and true. The catch is the pause, not a new habit of sneering. Sneering is just another costume.

Ask a Grown-Up

What finished-sounding sentence did you refuse to applaud this week?

Chapter 6: The Whole Path

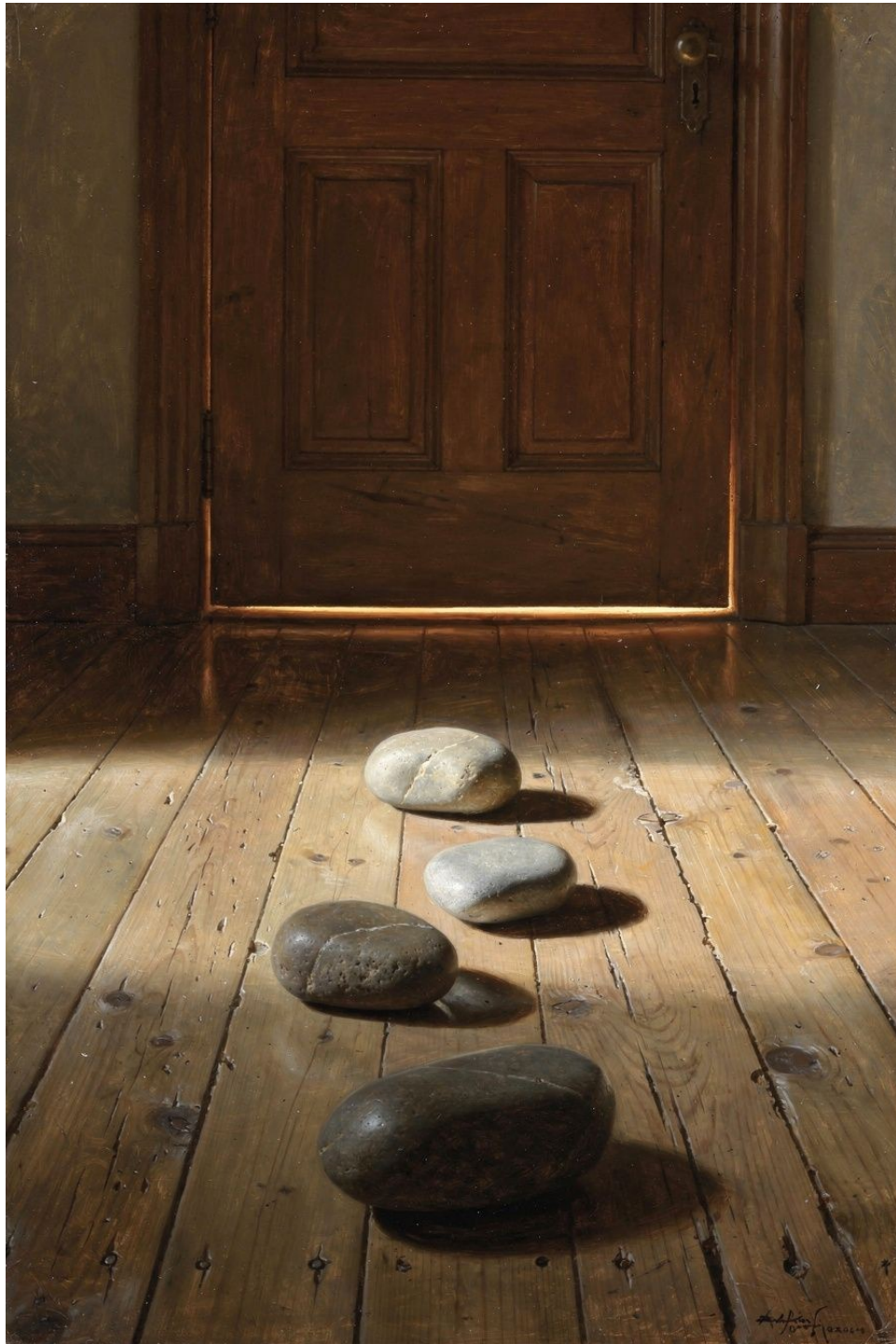


Illustration for Chapter 6

Claim. Kind hearing. What would change us. What the word means. Catch the smooth one. Then we know what we did.

Objective. The child can walk one small claim through check, kind hearing, and a brave change — on paper, before a tool.

For the grown-up in the room. Capstone. Keep it tiny. You are assembling sittings 1–5, not adding a new trick. Praise the path, not a win. Walk yours too. If you skip this because it is a lot for dinner, they will still have six names on a page and no memory of a house that used them. One small walk beats a speech.

One claim, the whole walk. We learned to check a sentence, to say the other person's idea until a nod, to change when we see more, to say what a word means, and to catch a sentence that is only smooth. Today we do all of it once, on something small. A talking tool may help with a word. It may not walk the path for us.

Paper is the thinking. If it only happens in a chat, it did not happen. Write the claim. Mark the check. If someone disagrees, nod test. If you changed, then / saw / now. If a word was fog, write the house meaning. If a sentence was only smooth, catch it.

One small walk is enough. Do not run a trial. Pick “the blue cup is mine” or “it always rains on Tuesdays.” Walk the names. If you skip a name because it feels slow, that is how houses get lost: they skip the nod, or they skip the word, or they applaud the smooth sentence and call it thinking.

Five names on a fridge card is a kindness. You do not recite them. You point when a skip happens. The capstone is the first time the house tries to use more than one name on the same claim.

Seen loops teach. Children will take the whole path to a model that never nods if they have never seen an adult walk it without a scoreboard. One true household walk teaches more than a speech about critical thinking.

Sitting big idea. Thinking is a path you can walk, not a feeling you had.

If they say “That’s too many steps.”: It is one walk with names. Skipping a name is how we get lost.

If they say “The tool can do the whole path.”: Faster is not the same as yours.

Integrity. We do not let a tool write the path and then sign our name.

Dinner. What path did we walk today — check, hear, change?

- Do not force a grown-up wound. - If they cry, stop.

Words to Remember

*“We are what we repeatedly do. Excellence, then, is not an act, but a habit.” — Will Durant, *The Story of Philosophy* (1926), restating Aristotle’s *Nicomachean Ethics* II.1*

*“Thinking is a path you can walk, not a feeling you had.” — WisdomForge sitting
*How to Think Capstone**

Big Idea

Walk the whole path on paper. The reply is last.

Try This

1. Write one small claim from this week. 2. CHECK: LOOK / ASK / TRY / NOT YET. 3. If someone disagrees: nod test. 4. If you changed: then / saw / now. 5. Ask a grown-up to walk theirs too. Guide closed until the paper exists.

What this is not: a performance for company. One claim. Five names if they fit. Skip a name that does not apply (no disagreement, skip the nod). Do not skip the check. Do not skip paper.

Ask a Grown-Up

When did this house walk the whole path, not just win?

For the Grown-Up Reader

The six sittings are live: `claim-and-check`, `steel-man`, `change-your-mind`, `say-what-you-mean`, `catch-the-fluent-claim`, `how-to-think-capstone`. This elementary booklet holds the same law at 5–10: write the claim, hear until a nod, name what would change you, freeze the word, catch smoothness, then walk the loop on paper.

Quotes are real. Peirce on doubt and belief; Mill on knowing only your own side; Popper on what would count against a theory; Wittgenstein on meaning as use; Kahneman on fluency and familiarity; Durant’s popular restatement of Aristotle on habit (the famous “we are what we repeatedly do” is Durant, 1926, not a verbatim line from the *Ethics* — do not teach the child that Aristotle wrote that English sentence). Sitting lines are WisdomForge teaching sentences, labeled as such.

Peirce’s 1877 essay is about how communities settle belief, not about scolding a child for feeling sure. Use the unease of doubt as a kitchen picture: the itch before you look in the jar. Mill’s chapter 2 is a political argument for free discussion; at this age the usable piece is “one side is not enough,” not a lecture on Parliament. Popper’s falsifiability is a standard for

scientific theories; here it is scaled to picnic weather, not to a child's identity. Wittgenstein §43 is about meaning as use in a language-game; the house sentence is the language-game that actually runs at this table. Kahneman's line is about repetition and familiarity; catch ads and fluent tools, not the child's favorite story. Durant is named so we do not launder a popular proverb into Aristotle.

The parent is the teacher. The guide is optional. AI never takes the first hand. Refusal is a complete week. No child data belongs on the site. If you pair a local guide, the sitting card copies `{ card, userMdLine }`. The pairing line on the page is display-only. The model does not become a friend, a judge, or a first hand.

About WisdomForge

WisdomForge makes four-band booklets so the same idea can sit on a kitchen table at four ages. The booklet is the text. The parent is the teacher. The guide is optional. Not a hosted kids chatbot. Does not make AI safe.

How to Think is an Academy subject pack, not an Operator title. It does not replace *Critical Thinking for Life* or the Hour set. It does not make a child a debater. It gives six names for one honest conversation: claim, hear, change, mean, catch, walk. If the house uses even three of them this month, the booklet did its job. If the house only downloads the PDF and never marks a paper, the sitting pages are still there. Use those. The download is a spine, not a trophy. Payment stays pulled. No child data on the site. Start at sitting 1: `/learn/little/thinking/claim-and-check`. Walk it this week. Paper first. The guide waits. Human first. Evaluate always. Parent in the loop. Does not make AI safe. Does not host a kids chatbot.